THE CLIENT ACQUISITION PLAYBOOK

A Practical System for Finding Leads, Booking Calls & Winning Clients



About this free sample

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A Practical System for Finding Leads, Booking Calls & Winning Clients

This sample shows the cover, the full contents, the ideal customer profile worksheet, two outreach templates, a discovery call script, the client qualification worksheet with scoring, and proposal frameworks, each with instructions and a filled example, exactly as they appear in the book.

The full book has 85 pages. Page numbers in the contents refer to the full book; sample pages keep their original page numbers.

This is an educational guide, not legal or tax advice. Rules on outreach, privacy and advertising differ by country; check the rules that apply to you. Examples are fictional. No results are promised.

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CHAPTER 3

Understanding ideal customers

From niche to person

A niche is a group. An ideal customer is a specific profile inside it: the company type, the person who decides, the trigger that makes them act, and the reasons they would say no. Writing it down lets you filter lists, personalise messages and qualify calls against criteria instead of mood.

Ideal customer profile worksheet

Copy this and fill it in for your niche. Complete every line; an empty line shows a decision you have not made.

```
IDEAL CUSTOMER PROFILE (ICP)

1. Niche in one sentence:
2. Company type and size (people, revenue band, locations):
3. Buyer role (who signs or pays):
4. Day to day contact (who you will talk to):
5. The problem, in their words:
6. What it costs them now (time, money, risk):
7. Triggers (events that make this urgent):
8. What they have already tried:
9. Budget range they can approve alone:
10. Where to find them (directories, communities, events):
11. Disqualifiers (traits that mean no):
12. Proof they would trust (case, number, referral):
```

```
13. Typical objections:
14. How I will contact them (channels):
```

Filled example (fictional)

```
1. Niche: Small architecture studios in the UK doing residential
work.
2. Company: 3 to 15 staff, owner led, one or two offices.
3. Buyer: Studio director or practice manager.
4. Contact: Same person.
5. Problem: "I never know which projects are making money."
6. Cost: Director spends about a day a month on invoices;
   late invoices delay cash.
7. Triggers: New hire, new project stage billing, year end,
   tax deadline, bank asking for accounts.
8. Tried: Spreadsheet, generic accountant, accounting software.
9. Budget: Can approve a monthly fee alone, not above
   a project sized sum without a partner.
10. Find: RIBA style directories, LinkedIn, local business
groups.
11. Disqualifiers: Wants lowest price only; no software in use
   and refuses any; owes unfiled accounts they will not share.
12. Proof: Two pilot studios, a before and after invoice
   timeline.
13. Objections: "My accountant does this." "We are too small."
14. Channels: Warm intros, email, LinkedIn note.
```

Triggers beat demographics

Two companies of the same size differ in readiness. A trigger is an observable event: a hire, a funding announcement, a new product page, a bad review, a job ad for the role you could replace, a website that has not changed in years. Triggers let your first line be about them, not you, and they explain why you are writing now.

Use buying committees honestly

In small firms the owner decides. In larger ones, three roles appear: the person with the problem, the person with the budget, and the person who can say no (legal, IT, finance). Ask early who else will be involved

(Chapter 11).

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Describing the customer as "any business that needs growth".
Fix: Name company type, size and trigger. If you cannot, you cannot find them.

Mistake: Writing the problem in your jargon.
Fix: Use the words buyers use in reviews, forum posts and calls. Update line 5 after every call.

Mistake: No disqualifiers.
Fix: Write three. They protect your time and your margin.

How to build a list of 50

Use one row per lead. Required fields: name, role, company, website, source, trigger, contact route, date found. If you cannot fill trigger and source, do not add the lead yet.

1. Define the filter from your ICP (size, region, type).
2. Collect 80 names from two sources.
3. Remove duplicates, competitors and anyone matching a disqualifier.
4. Find the right person: owner for small firms; head of the relevant function for larger ones.
5. Write one line of relevant observation per lead (the trigger). If you cannot write it in under two minutes, drop the lead.

Do not buy scraped lists, and do not use tools that harvest LinkedIn data. Appendix A explains why. Build smaller lists by hand; 50 well researched leads outperform 500 careless ones in the only way that matters here, they are safe to contact and easy to personalise.

Warm outreach templates

Warm messages work because the relationship does the heavy lifting. Keep them short, specific and easy to decline.

01. Referral ask to a happy client

When to use: within a month of a successful delivery, or at a natural review point.

Instructions: Name the result they got. Describe the kind of person you want to meet in one sentence. Offer to write the introduction text for them.

```
Subject: A small favour, if you are happy to

Hi Priya,
```

Rules that make calls useful

- Talk less than 40% of the time.
- Write the buyer's own words down; use them in the proposal.
- Ask "what else?" before moving on.
- Ask about budget plainly and early enough to avoid wasting both sides' time.
- End with a dated next step, such as "I will send the proposal on Thursday and we speak Monday at 10."

Ten scripts by situation

Each script is a question set. The example shows the questions filled in for a fictional business, Reed Books, a bookkeeping practice for small studios. Adapt the wording to your trade.

C1. Inbound lead (they contacted you)

When to use: a form submission or email asking for help.

Instructions: Confirm what prompted the enquiry, then follow the structure. Do not assume their stated request is the real problem.

```
1. What made you reach out this week?
2. What happens today when an invoice needs to go out?
3. What is the effect when invoices are late?
4. What have you tried, and what happened?
5. If this were solved by month end, what changes for you?
6. Who else is involved in a decision like this?
7. Do you have a budget range in mind?
8. When would you like this running?
Close: "I will send a written proposal by Thursday."
```

C2. Referral call

When to use: someone you know introduced you.

Instructions: Thank the referrer, check what they told the prospect, and do not rely on borrowed trust.

CHAPTER 11

Client qualification

Why qualify

Not every lead is a good client. Working with a poor fit costs time, margin and attention. Qualification is a structured judgement made after learning enough, and it protects both sides. You can say no politely and refer them elsewhere.

Qualification worksheet

Score each factor from 0 to 2 (0 weak, 1 partial, 2 strong). Maximum 20.

```
CLIENT QUALIFICATION WORKSHEET

Lead: _______  Date: _______

1. Problem is real and named by them            (0-2)
2. Cost of the problem is clear                 (0-2)
3. Urgency: a reason to act within 90 days      (0-2)
4. Budget: range stated or confirmed            (0-2)
5. Authority: decision maker is on the call     (0-2)
6. Fit: matches my ICP and service              (0-2)
7. Scope is clear and realistic                 (0-2)
8. Communication: responsive, respectful        (0-2)
9. Payment: terms accepted in principle         (0-2)
10. Access: can provide inputs when needed      (0-2)

Total: ___ / 20
```

How to read the score

Score	Action
16 to 20	Send a proposal within 48 hours
11 to 15	Fix the weak factors first (ask, clarify, involve the decision maker)
6 to 10	Nurture; send resources; check in later
0 to 5	Politely decline and refer

Two rules override the total. Any score of 0 on Authority or Budget means you cannot send a final proposal yet. A score of 0 on Communication or Payment means you pause, because these predict trouble later.

These cut offs are a decision aid I propose, not a validated statistical model. Adjust them after you review 20 of your own deals.

Worked example (fictional)

Lead: Ridgeline Studio, director Ellis Wong.

Factor	Score	Reason
Problem	2	"Invoices wait weeks"
Cost	1	Cash flow mentioned, not quantified
Urgency	2	Year end in 8 weeks
Budget	1	Gave a monthly figure, not total
Authority	2	Ellis signs
Fit	2	In ICP
Scope	1	Unsure about second office
Communication	2	Replied same day
Payment	1	Wants quarterly invoicing
Access	2	Will share data on day one

Total 16. Action: send a proposal within 48 hours. Open items before sending: quantify cost, confirm scope for the second office, agree payment terms.

Red flags

- Refuses to say who decides.
- Asks for free sample work on their real project.
- Disputes price before knowing scope.
- Talks about previous providers with contempt and no self reflection.
- Wants a start date before agreeing terms.
- Cannot describe what success looks like.

A red flag is a question, not a verdict. Ask about it directly and judge the answer.

Saying no well

```
Hi Ellis, thank you for the detail. After thinking it
through, I am not the right fit for this one because
[honest reason, e.g. the scope needs a specialist in
multi site tax]. I can recommend [name] who does that. If
things change, I am happy to talk again.
```

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Qualifying only on whether they can pay.
Fix: Use all ten factors; payment is one.

Mistake: Ignoring a low score because you need work.
Fix: Decide the minimum score in advance, when you are calm.

Mistake: Not updating the score.
Fix: Rescore after the proposal meeting.

Five proposal frameworks

P1. One page proposal

When to use: small projects, quick decisions.

Instructions: Keep it to one page; present in the call or follow with a short call.

```
Ridgeline Studio, billing setup. Prepared 12 Nov.

Situation: Invoices go out up to 3 weeks late; month end
takes a day for the director.
Goal: Invoices out within 5 days of a stage signing; one
profit report per project.
Approach: 1) Map stages. 2) Configure software. 3) Build the
report. 4) Train staff.
Included: setup, template, one training session, 30 days of
support. Not included: tax advice, data cleanup older than
12 months.
Timeline: 3 weeks from start date.
Investment: 1,800 fixed. 50% on acceptance, 50% on delivery.
To start: reply "yes" and I will send the agreement.
```

P2. Three option proposal

When to use: the buyer is price sensitive or unsure about scope.

Instructions: Offer three levels. The middle one should be the one you want; the others make choice easy.

```
Option A, Essentials: Setup and report. 1,800.
Option B, Recommended: Setup, report, 3 months of monthly
 close with review call. 3,600.
Option C, Full: Option B plus quarterly planning and
 year end preparation. 5,400.
All options: 3 week setup. Payment: 50% on acceptance,
balance on delivery (monthly services billed monthly).
Differences: B adds ongoing close; C adds planning.
```